

CASH-LANDRUM RADIATION CASE

By John F. Schuessler

12-29-80

(Note: This follow-up report is based on a presentation to the Sept. 1981 CUFOS UFO Conference. The case was initially reported in the Apr. 1981 issue, No. 158.)

The problem of radiation sickness caused by UFOs is defined by these brief examples:

October 24, 1887: Venezuelan family exposed to a brightly lit unidentified flying object (UFO) and suffered burns, vomiting, hair loss, and extensive swelling.

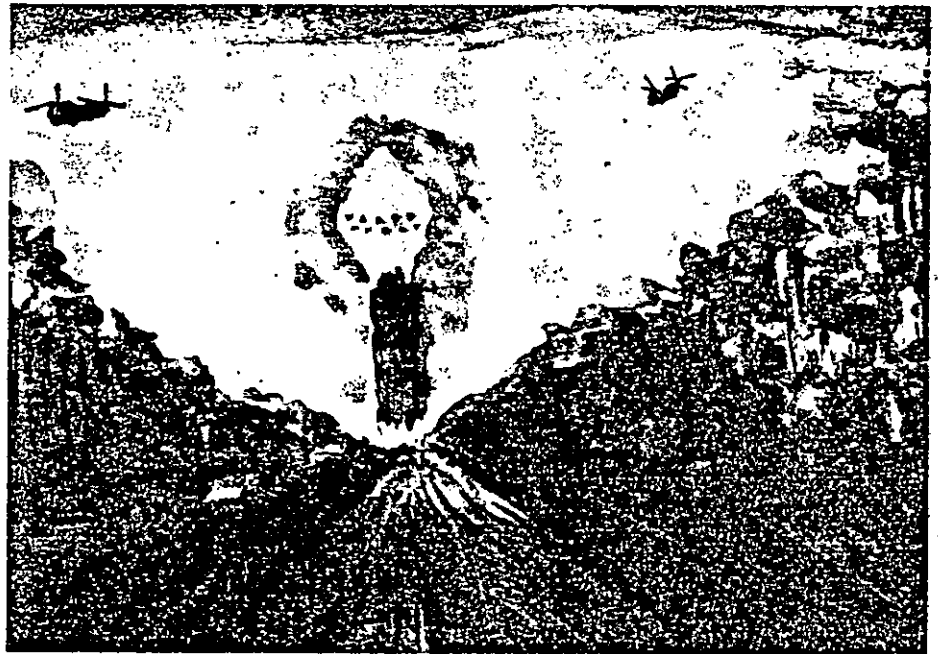
May 20, 1967: Canadian prospector Stephen Michalak encountered a landed UFO and suffered burns, nausea, vomiting, swelling and an extended illness.

October 3, 1973: Missouri truck driver exposed to an extremely bright UFO, blinded for days, and had vision impairment for a year.

These and hundreds of similar incidents indicate that UFOs are seriously affecting people. How can these people be helped? What can we learn about UFOs by studying these human effects?

A small team of engineers, scientists, and medical specialists have formed Project VISIT (Vehicle Internal Systems Investigative Team), to be a clearinghouse for all UFO incidents involving medical injury or alleged entry into a UFO. VISIT members collect and analyze data on the physical effects of UFOs on people. This scientific and medical data is then examined to discover the probable mechanisms of the UFO.

The latest entry into the VISIT data base occurred on December 29, 1980, when three Texans encountered a UFO and suffered severe medical consequences. Betty Cash (51), Vickie Landrum (57), and Vickie's grandson Colby Landrum (7), were driving home to Dayton, Texas, on the Cleveland-Huffman road just north of Lake Houston. It was 9 o'clock at



Artist's Rendition of the Sighting
(By Kathy Schuessler)

night and the road was deserted. The first indication of something unusual was the presence of a very intense light several miles ahead just above the pine trees. Betty remarked about the unusual brightness, but temporarily lost sight of it due to the many trees along the road.

Suddenly, hovering over the road only a short distance ahead was an enormous diamond-shaped object. "It was like a diamond of fire," Vickie said. The glow was so intense they could barely stand to look at it. Vickie at first thought it was the fulfillment of biblical prophecy and expected Jesus to come out of the fire in the sky.

In addition to lighting the whole area like daytime, the UFO periodically belched flames downward. Fearing they would be burned alive Betty stopped the 1980 Oldsmobile Cutlass without leaving the road. They all got out of the car to get a

better look at the UFO. Colby was terrified and dove back into the car, begging his grandma to get back in, too. Vickie did and comforted Colby.

Betty stood momentarily by the driver's door and then walked forward to the front of the car. After much pleading by Vickie, Betty finally returned to the car. The door handle was so hot she used her leather coat as a hotpad to open the door. Although the winter night air had been about 40°F, the heat from the UFO caused the witnesses to sweat and feel so uncomfortable that they turned on the car's air conditioner.

Each time the object would shoot flames downward it would rise. As the flames stopped it would drop in altitude. The intense glow, however, never changed. In addition, the threesome heard an irregular beeping sound throughout the sighting.

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Radiation, Continued

Finally, the flames stopped, the object rose to the south-west, and was lost from sight. Vickie and Colby commented that several helicopters could be seen above and beyond the UFO. Vickie said with relief, "we're safe and we're sound, but I'm burning and it's so hot."

Betty was directly exposed to the object 5 to 10 minutes, Vickie 3 to 5 minutes, and Colby only a minute or so. As Betty raced homeward she turned right on FM 2100. Five minutes had lapsed and just ahead was the UFO and a large number of helicopters. "The sky was full of helicopters," Betty said. Some were near the object and others lagged behind. She feared the helicopters would collide. They were dazzled as they counted more than 20 helicopters. According to Vickie, "The helicopter roar was like a tornado."

They sped onward towards home, turning on to the Huffman-Eastgate road, then to FM 1960. By this time the object had been in sight, climbing into the night sky, for another 5 minutes. On FM 1960 the threesome were going away from the UFO, but could still observe it as a diminishing bright light for 2 or 3 more minutes.

Unusual Medical Effects

Betty dropped Vickie and Colby in Dayton and arrived home at 9:05 p.m. where her friend Wilma was waiting. Vickie said as she left the car, "My head hurts, I'm sick." Betty felt even worse. In addition to a terrible headache and nausea, her neck began to swell and red blotches appeared on her face and head.

December 29th was a turning point in the lives of Betty and Vickie. Betty, an unusually energetic woman, had plans to open a new restaurant. The sickness that followed ruined those plans. For the next four days Betty's health degraded. Her eyes swelled closed, the red blotches became blisters of clear fluid, and she was weak with diarrhea and nausea. The headaches never ceased. Because Betty was unable to function, Vickie was afraid she would die and set out to locate her doctor.



Sighting Location; l. Alan Holt; r. Vickie Landrum



Betty Cash Showing Hair Loss

After a number of telephone calls a doctor instructed Vickie to take Betty to the hospital emergency room where the staff received and treated her as a burn patient. Over the next several days Betty lost patches of skin on her face and about 50% of her hair fell out.

After 12 days in the hospital Betty went home, even though she had shown little improvement. Her condition again degraded to the point

where she returned to the hospital for 15 more days. During the weeks that followed the incident, Vickie treated herself and Colby with baby oil to stop the burning of their faces. Their stomach pains and diarrhea stopped after a couple of weeks but their eyes are apparently permanently damaged and treatment continues. Colby had nightmares for weeks and was ex-

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Radiation, Continued

tremely frightened by bright lights in the night sky or by helicopters anytime.

SUMMARY OF THE MEDICAL EFFECTS

Colby Erythema (reddening of the skin)

- Eyes swollen and watery
- Stomach pains
- Diarrhea
- Anorexia (loss of appetite)
- Some weight loss
- Increase in tooth cavities

Vickie Erythema

- Photophthalmia (eyes swollen, watery, and painful)
- Vision greatly diminished
- Stomach pains
- Diarrhea
- Anorexia
- Ulceration on the arms, resulting in scarring and loss of pigmentation
- Keratin affected resulting in fingernail damage
- Hair loss
- Hair regrowth of a different texture

Betty Erythema

- Acute photophthalmia (eyes swollen closed, painful, watery)
- Vision impaired
- Stomach pains
- Vomiting, diarrhea
- Anorexia
- Loss of energy, lethargy
- Scarring and loss of skin pigmentation
- Excessive hair loss
- Hair regrowth of a different texture

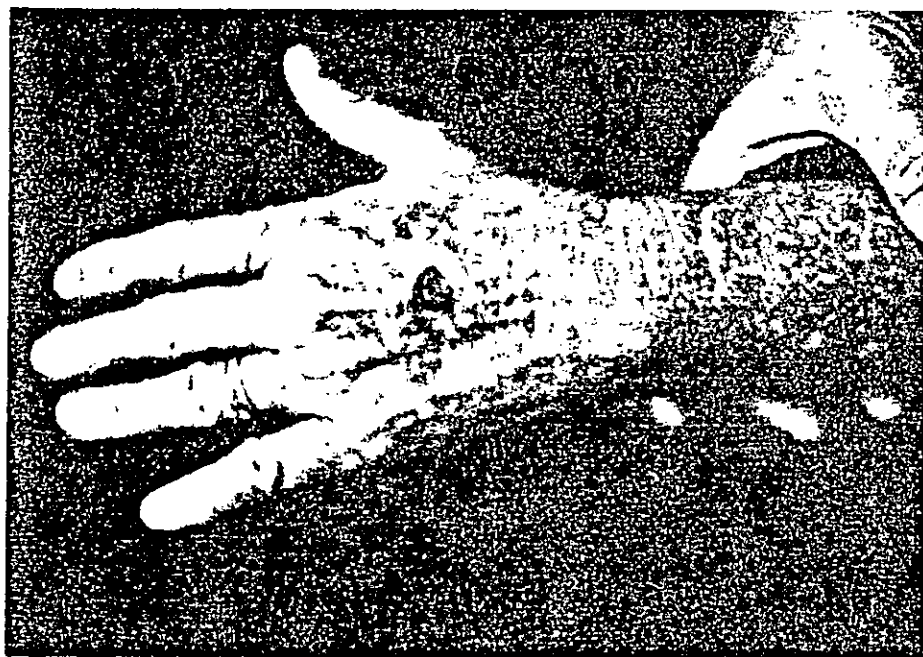
The electromagnetic spectrum is divided into groups according to wavelengths. X-rays and gamma rays have very short wavelengths; ultraviolet radiation, visible light, and infrared have increasingly longer wavelengths. Since the regions overlap, an exposed person may suffer effects of more than one region — x-ray and ultraviolet for example.

Exposure to ultraviolet radiation can produce photophobia, photophthalmia (arc-eye), edema of the eyelids, and erythema of the skin. Exposure to gamma and x-radiation can provide a strong general weakness, anorexia, nausea, vomiting, apathy, severe headache, sleeplessness, and ziness.

The symptoms provide a clue to the type of radiation exposure. The degree of illness depends upon the type and energy of the radiation, the



Vickie Landrum: Photophobia Eye Condition



Vickie Landrum: Sores Persist After 8 Months

dose, amount of exposure, and a number of other variables. However, there is no type of radiation that is not potentially dangerous to the eye. Certainly most of the listed symptoms can be found in the Cash/Landrum incident.

The Helicopters

All the witnesses were interrogated separately for information about the helicopters. They all agreed there

were at least 20. Illumination from the glowing object clearly showed details of the helicopters even though the night was dark and the moon was in the third quarter. At least two different helicopter models were present, but they referred also to the one large thing amidst the helicopters.

Through use of helicopter identification charts one model was clearly identified as the Boeing CH-47

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Radiation, Continued

Chinook. Another was identified as being similar to the Bell Huey model, but not positively identified as such.

Each of the witnesses not only identified the shape and main characteristics of the Chinook, they also pointed out details such as the wheels, lighting pattern, and sounds.

Contact with the Houston International Airport FAA representative provided the following:

- 350-400 helicopters operate commercially in the Houston area.
- All are single rotor types (no Chinooks).
- Helicopter traffic flies Visual Flight Rules (VFR), consequently they do not contact the tower.
- Beyond 15 miles from the airport they must stay below 1,800 feet.
- The Houston radar is limited to 2,000-2,200 feet around Lake Houston due to the location of antenna.

Contact with military installations was of little help. Fort Polk, Fort Hood, Dallas Naval Air Station, and England AFB stated they did not fly into the Houston area that evening. The unit operating out of Ellington AFB in Houston had landed before the sighting time. Robert Gray Field had 100 helicopters come in from the field at one time "for effect," but claimed to have avoided the Houston area. Hence, no one claims the helicopters that filled the Huffman area sky that winter night.

Conclusion

This incident clearly points up several serious conditions. First, when a person is involved in a close encounter with a UFO they find it nearly impossible to obtain immediate assistance. The police, newspapers, and even doctors receive their plea for help with tongue in cheek. The doctors, being unprepared for a bizarre account like Betty's, spend a lot of time trying to determine what is wrong, as a standard treatment method has never been defined.

Second, military organizations could better serve the citizens of the



Distinctive Silhouette of CH-47 Helicopter

United States if they were prepared to relate the nature of objects such as the one at Huffman and others where public safety is at stake. Betty and Vickie have never said the Huffman UFO was a flying saucer with little green men. They believe it was a government-sponsored operation of some kind. Others that saw and heard the helicopters that evening have the same feeling.

Third, UFO organizations usually do not cooperate to the fullest to help the witnesses. The Huffman incident is an exception. The Mutual UFO Network of Seguin, Texas, the Center for UFO Studies of Evanston, Illinois, and the Aerial Phenomena Research Organization of Tucson, Arizona, all cooperated in a responsible manner to

assist the Houston-based, Project VISIT to conduct the investigation by providing consultants, recommendations, and data pertaining to similar cases. Such cooperation is in the best interest of all parties involved.

The investigation continues. The future health state of Betty, Vickie, and Colby is yet to be determined. However, several radiation specialists have given freely of their time and talents to establish a program of rehabilitation and care. Full treatment is still lacking because the data on the source of the problem, the UFO, is still not available.

Project VISIT members are available on call for consultation. The address of VISIT is Post Office Box 877, Friendswood, Texas 77546.

(Photographs provided by John Schuessler)

MEDICAL NETWORK

Project UFOMD — a network of doctors to intensively study UFO-related injury cases — has been organized by radiologist Richard C. Niemtzw. Before being called to active duty in the Air Force, Dr. Niemtzw was active in MUFON and Project VISIT in the Houston, Texas, area. Doctors in the MUFON network are invited to contact Dr. Niemtzw and offer their services.

Over about a 2-year period he hopes to investigate and assess a minimum of 12 cases dealing with medical injuries incurred during UFO close encounters, and possibly pro-

duce a catalogue correlating the resulting data. Investigators aware of such cases are urged to have the witness consult a physician, of their own choice, and Dr. Niemtzw will be available as a consultant to the primary physician. Clinical and laboratory tests should be conducted on the witness in each case.

Interested physicians, including doctors working with patients reporting UFO-related injuries, should contact Dr. Niemtzw at (707) 446-5050 or write to him at 532 Merchant St., Vacaville, CA 95688.

State, private agencies probing claim of UFO encounter

BY CINDY HORSWELL
Chronicle Staff

The Texas Department of Health and three private agencies are investigating reports that two Dayton women and a child may have been exposed to an unidentified flying object and suffered radiation exposure as a result.

It was a cold, cloudy evening on Dec. 29 when Vickie Landrum, 57, a waitress, and her former employer, Betty Cash, 52, then owner of a cafe in Dayton, and Mrs. Landrum's 7-year-old grandson, Colby Landrum, were driving from New Caney to Dayton.

Along an uninhabited stretch of FM 1485, about 30 miles northwest of Houston near Huffman and about 15 miles west of Dayton, they spotted something strange. "I saw a long, red thing in the sky about three miles ahead," said Mrs. Landrum. "I was trying to figure out what it was."

She said that within minutes the object was in front of them. Mrs. Landrum said she screamed at Mrs. Cash to stop the car and they all jumped out.

Colby, who lives with Mrs. Landrum, ran back to the car a minute later and hid on the floorboard, said Mrs. Landrum. She said she remained outside about four minutes and Mrs. Cash, the driver, got the closest to the object and watched it for about 10 minutes.

"It was diamond-shaped and as tall as a water tower," Mrs. Landrum said. "It was a dull, gray metallic color, and it just floated there."

She said red-orange flames were intermittently spewing from the bottom and that it produced a noise she will never forget. "It made a roaring sound like a flame thrower and then high-pitched beeps. It had a flammable smell, like lighter fluid," she said. The heat, she said, was so intense that it caused sweat to pour off her and her companions.

"It was so bright. The glow lit everything up. It was as if the whole woods was on fire," she said.

As the object began heading to the northwest, said Mrs. Landrum, she saw large, double-rotary helicopters following it. She said she and her grandson counted about 25 helicopters.

"It (the object) was a monstrous thing. It seemed like it was having trouble flying, and so it would let out those flames and then shoot up again while making that shrill beeping sound," said Mrs. Cash, a divorcee who is now staying with her elderly mother in Fairfield, Ala.

Mrs. Cash went to Alabama recently to recuperate from burns, blisters, weakness, diarrhea, headaches, eye problems and loss of hair — all problems she attributes to her encounter with the flying object. Mrs. Cash lost about 50 percent of her hair and had to be hospitalized twice after the sighting.

Mrs. Landrum said she had similar symptoms, but to a lesser degree. Colby was nauseated and had "kind of a bad sunburn." They say the degree of illness corresponded to the



Photo by Cindy Horswell, Chronicle Staff

Vickie Landrum, a 57-year-old Dayton waitress, says she and two other Dayton residents saw a strange object in the sky nine months ago. Since then, the three have experience symptoms similar to the effects of radiation exposure.

length of time each was outside the car and bathed in the bright light.

"I felt so hot inside, as if I was burning from the inside out," Mrs. Cash said. "The heat blinded me and I could barely see."

Along an uninhabited stretch of FM 1485, about 30 miles north-west of Houston near Huffman and about 15 miles west of Dayton, they spotted something strange. "I saw a long, red thing in the sky about three miles ahead," said Vickie Landrum. "I was trying to figure out what it was."

The trio broke their secrecy pact then and told doctors about the incident. Mrs. Landrum also reported it to Dayton Police Chief Tommy Waring.

Waring said he has known Mrs. Landrum for about 30 years and "after talking to her for 35 or 40 minutes, you knew she was reporting what she thought she saw. She appeared highly nervous and upset."

Mrs. Landrum said her hair began to "come out in wads" and her eyesight began failing about three weeks after the incident. She then sought medical attention. Her hair has since regrown, though she says it now has a burnt, frizzed texture.

The three have been interviewed by John F. Schuessler, a mechanical engineer employed as McDonnell-Douglas' project manager for space flight operations in Clear Lake City. He is investigating her case in his capacity as a volunteer with the Mutual UFO Network.

He and Dr. J. Allen Hynek, founder of the Center for UFO Studies in Evanston, Ill., say the Dayton incident is the most significant sighting that has occurred in the Houston area in 10

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years. "That's because there is something you can actually examine afterward — the physical injuries," said Schuessler.

Dr. P.B. Patil, a specialist in cardiology and internal medicine, said he and his colleagues hospitalized Mrs. Cash twice at Parkway Hospital in Houston for a total of about 3 1/2 weeks. "She definitely had a bad burn on her face and her hair came out in clumps in two or three areas," he said.

He said consultants were called in, but "we cannot say for sure what caused it." "From the people we rule out radiation exposure."

Dr. Steve Chandler, a Liberty optometrist, treated Mrs.

Dr. James Easley, a Houston radiologist, examined the women more than six months after the incident but said his results were not conclusive because he saw the women so late.

Schuessler has two theories about the sighting: Either the object came from another planet or it was an experimental top-secret U.S. government project.

To substantiate the trio's story, Schuessler has gathered reports from several persons in the area who also say they saw something strange.

On that same night, Angie Stanley, 26, a Dayton postal clerk, was coming home from New Caney on FM 1485 about 13 miles west of Dayton. "I saw a really bright light in the sky pretty far away," she said. "It looked like the bright headlights of a car on an oval-shaped thing."

Jerry McDonald, 24, an oil field roughneck, also witnessed something strange that night from his home in Dayton. "I heard a sound like a rumble, and I thought it was the Goodyear blimp," he said. "It was kind of triangular or diamond-shaped and had two twin torches that were shooting brilliant blue flames out the back." He said it also had two bright lights on it and a red light in the center as it passed about 150 feet above him.

Belle Magee, 55, a bakery clerk, was in her home in Eastgate, about eight miles west of Dayton, when she looked out and saw a bright light heading in the direction of New Caney. "It was bright like the light of a football field, but up in the sky," she said.

Dayton police officer J.L. Walker was off duty and driving home from Cleveland, five miles north of Dayton on FM 321 when he saw several large helicopters flying in formation. He says he is not sure of the exact date, but thinks it may have been Dec. 29.

To jog Mrs. Landrum's memory, she was hypnotized twice by Dr. R. Leo Sprinkle, a psychologist and director of counseling and testing at the University of Wyoming. Sprinkle has studied about 250 persons who have reported UFO sightings during the last 20 years.

Under hypnosis, Mrs. Landrum did not reveal any new details, he said, but she did not alter her story, either.

"She showed very dramatically what her feelings were as she relived it," he said. "She kept pulling on her blouse and cradling her arm like she was holding Colby close. She said she thought it was the end of the world and Jesus was coming out of the light."

Sprinkle said there is no way to know if a person is hypnotized, but based on 15 years experience, she was — or else she has been taking acting lessons. "Hypnosis really does not prove an incident happened," he said, but "it's her truth, what the individual thinks is true."

At the request of state Rep. Larry Browner, D-Caldspring, the Texas Department of Health's Bureau of Radiation Control is investigating the Dayton incident.

"We came into this thing fairly late in the game," said Russ Meyer, manager of the state's public health department in Houston.

On Sept. 16, he drove the stretch of road where the sighting is supposed to have occurred. His radiation detection equipment did not find any traces of remnant radiation in the area. He also took soil samples, but testing of them is not complete yet.

"If there had been radioactive contamination in large amounts, some would still be left there," he said. However, he said certain types of radiation — such as ultraviolet light, infrared light and low-energy X-rays — might not leave any residual traces.

Meyer has recommended that the trio's medical records be reviewed by the state health department's medical advisory board. Specialists, he said, could differentiate between radiation and symptoms that could be attributed to such things as chemical toxins.

The helicopters, he said, that the women would appear to be CH-47 Chinooks, used by the military as troop carriers. However, spokesmen for the Army and National Guard, both of which keep helicopters in the Houston area, said there are no records of military helicopters being flown on Dec. 29.

Attorney Peter Gersten of the Bronx, N.Y., representing Citizens Against UFO Secrecy, said he is interested in the Dayton women and "particularly interested in things to do with the military."

Two weeks ago, he sent letters to the National Guard and U.S. Air Force headquarters requesting information on helicopters which may have been involved with the "startling encounter of a UFO" near Dayton and requesting all records they might possess on the subject.

Military authorities said his letter has been forwarded to their legal departments.

Dayton Police Chief Tommy Waring said he has known Mrs. Landrum for about 30 years and "after talking to her for 35 or 40 minutes, you knew she was re-